1 Evidence Lab

Measure a footprint, test a powder · You hand out: **CLUE 1** envelopes

THE ACTIVITY

A painted footprint was "found" by the shelf where the jar sat. The group measures it in centimeters, converts it to a shoe size on a chart, then tests a mystery powder from the scene against three known powders by dropping each into vinegar. Only baking soda fizzes.

> **WHEN A GROUP ARRIVES, SAY**
> "Every footprint tells a story. Measure twice. Then let's find out what that powder is."

RUN IT

1. Count the kids off 1 to 5. Kids 1 and 2 measure the footprint with a ruler, in centimeters. They should get 26. If they disagree, measure once more together.
2. Flip over the shoe-size chart. 26 cm = size 9. Kid 3 writes "size 9" in the group's case file.
3. Kid 4 drops a spoonful of FLOUR into the cup of vinegar. Nothing. Then POWDERED SUGAR. Nothing. Then BAKING SODA. It fizzes up.
4. Kid 5 drops the EVIDENCE powder into the same cup. It fizzes. Say: "The thief left baking soda at the scene. Remember that." Kid 5 writes "baking soda" in the case file.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 1 envelope. Don't open it. Then dump the vinegar cup in the bucket and pour an inch of fresh.

HOW IT FITS THE STORY

Your clue: the thief wears a size 9. CLUE 1 says the footprint is 26 cm, a size 9. The group checks that against the four suspects' statement forms: the Librarian is a size 7 (Bureau records), everyone else wrote 9. Your table clears **the Librarian**.

The powder is a setup, not a clue. It proves the thief left baking soda at the scene. The ghosts at table 2 are baking soda, so the group arrives there knowing vinegar opens them. (Group already did table 2? "Recognize it? That's what the ghosts were made of.")

Say "candy" until the first video has played (about 1:50); "squishies" after. Never say who did it.

On your table: the footprint under a plastic sheet, rulers, the shoe-size chart (face down), three labeled powder cups with spoons, the EVIDENCE bag with a spoon, one clear cup of vinegar, the vinegar bottle and a dump bucket under the table, paper towels, four CLUE 1 envelopes.

2 Ghostbuster Lab

Fizz the ghosts, find the words · You hand out: **CLUE 2** envelopes

THE ACTIVITY

Five baking-soda "ghosts" sit in a bin, each hiding a laminated word slip. Every kid squirts one with green vinegar until it fizzes apart, then the group puts the five words in order to read a sentence.

> **WHEN A GROUP ARRIVES, SAY**
> "These ghosts are holding evidence hostage. The only thing they can't survive is vinegar. One syringe each. Bust them."

RUN IT

1. Count the kids off 1 to 5. Put five ghosts in the bin, one per kid. Each kid gets a syringe of green vinegar. Sleeves up.
2. They squirt their ghost until it fizzes apart. A small word slip is hidden inside each one.
3. Everyone lays their word on the table and moves them around until it reads like a sentence: **SEEN IN HALL AT 2:15.** Whoever has SEEN reads it out loud. Whoever has 2:15 writes it in the group's case file.
4. Say: "So now you know when it happened." That's it. Don't explain more.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 2 envelope. Don't open it. Then scoop the mush into the bin, wipe the table, and set out five fresh ghosts from the muffin tins.

HOW IT FITS THE STORY

Your clue: the theft happened at 2:15. Until a group reaches your table, nobody knows when the jar was taken; the case file just says "afternoon." The ghosts spell SEEN IN HALL AT 2:15, and CLUE 2 says the same. The Principal's statement says he was off campus at a meeting from 1:00 to 3:00, so he couldn't have been in the hall. Your table clears **the Principal**.

Don't mention the time before the words come out of the ghosts; the surprise is the point.

Say "candy" until the first video has played (about 1:50); "squishies" after. Never say who did it.

On your table: a tablecloth with a big plastic bin on it, 25 ghosts in muffin tins (use 5 per group), a pitcher of green vinegar, 6 syringes, paper towels and wipes, four CLUE 2 envelopes.

3 The Cipher Room

Decode a note, find the hidden message · You hand out: **CLUE 3** envelopes



THE ACTIVITY

The thief left a ransom note written in a symbol code. The group decodes it with a key, one word per kid. Then they sweep the page with a blacklight and a hidden line, written in highlighter, glows.

> **WHEN A GROUP ARRIVES, SAY**
> "The thief left a note and thinks we can't read it. Prove them wrong. Then check the paper again. Thieves always leave something behind."

RUN IT

1. Count the kids off 1 to 5. Give the group one ransom note and the symbol key. The note has five words; each kid decodes one word, writing letters on the lines under the symbols. It says **YOU WILL NEVER FIND IT.** About 3 minutes. Give a hint if they're stuck.
2. When kid 1 has read the whole note out loud, hand kid 2 the blacklight flashlight: "Now sweep the light across the whole page."
3. A hidden line glows at the bottom: **SNAGGED SOMETHING ORANGE ON THE SHELF. WORTH IT.** Kid 3 reads it out loud. Kid 4 writes it in the group's case file.
4. Time left? Each kid writes a short message in symbols on a take-home card to give someone at home.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 3 envelope. Don't open it. Then take the key back. The used note stays with you.

HOW IT FITS THE STORY

Your clue: the thief wore orange. The decoded note is just a taunt. The hidden P.S. is the evidence, and CLUE 3 says the same. The Principal and the Reading Specialist wrote that they wore orange for Halloween week, and Bureau records say the Librarian did too; the Custodian's records say a gray work shirt. Your table clears **the Custodian**.

The take-home cards are just for fun; they don't affect the case.

Say "candy" until the first video has played (about 1:50); "squishies" after. Never say who did it.

On your table: four ransom notes, the symbol key, pencils, two blacklight flashlights, a stack of take-home message cards, four CLUE 3 envelopes.

4 The Mummy Witness

Wrap a mummy, send it to the box · You hand out: **CLUE 4** envelopes



THE ACTIVITY

The only witness to the theft is a mummy, and mummies only talk to other mummies. Four kids wrap the fifth in toilet paper in ninety seconds; the mummy hobbles to the witness box and brings back the witness statement.

> **WHEN A GROUP ARRIVES, SAY**
> "I am the witness. I saw everything. But I only speak to mummies. You have ninety seconds. Make me one."

RUN IT

1. Count the kids off 1 to 5. Kid 5 is the mummy: stands on the tape line, arms out. Kids 1 to 4 each get one roll of toilet paper and one limb (left arm, right arm, left leg, right leg). Whoever finishes first wraps the body.
2. Start the stopwatch: 90 seconds. Eyes and mouth stay uncovered. Call out the last ten seconds.
3. Say: "Time. Mummy, the witness box is ten feet away. Only a mummy may open it. Go." The mummy hobbles to the box, tears free, opens the lid (the clue is printed inside it) and takes ONE envelope.
4. Kid 1 reads the witness statement out loud, ending with the boxed clue. Kid 2 writes "squishies" on the Mummy Witness line of the case file. Kids 3 and 4 stuff every scrap of paper into the trash bag.
5. Time left? Do it again with a new mummy and a time to beat.

When the bell rings: hand the group ONE sealed CLUE 4 envelope. Don't open it. Then put out four fresh rolls.

HOW IT FITS THE STORY

Your clue: the thief REALLY likes squishies. It is printed inside the lid of the witness box and in the box at the bottom of every statement. The story around it (the avocado one, "so satisfying," the puppy hug) is just flavor. CLUE 4 says the same thing. Three suspects ticked LOVE THEM; the Reading Specialist ticked DON'T GET THEM. Your table clears **the Reading Specialist**.

Groups that reach you after the first video (about 1:50) already know the jar held squishies, not candy. Before that, say "candy"; the statement still works. Never say who did it.

On your table: 20 rolls of cheap toilet paper, a stopwatch, trash bags, a tape line on the floor and the witness box ten feet away (clue sign inside the lid, four identical statements inside), four CLUE 4 envelopes.

FL

Floater / Photographer

Door, badges, restocks, photos, the hidden tags

Arrive 1:00 · Whole party



Before 1:30

- Crime-scene tape on the door frame (door stays usable). LED candle at each station.
- Cauldron and the Evidence Locker (under a cloth) by the Chief's desk.
- Spare badges and 5 case files on the door table.

Timeline

1. **1:30** Door: kids wear the badge they filled in at training (1 purple, 2 black, 3 teal, 4 orange); spare badges and the squad list for anyone whose badge went missing. Each squad gets its numbered case file. Point each squad to the station with its number.
2. **1:38 to 2:28** Rotations: bathroom runs in pairs, restock stations (TP, vinegar, wipes), photos of each station (check the opt-out list first).
3. **Each bell:** dim the lights while the Detective plays the video; back up to "dim" when it ends.
4. **Rotation 3 (2:04):** hide the 20 highlighter-marked evidence tags around the room: under desks, inside books, under chairs. Nobody notices; they're busy.
5. **2:28** Deliberation: lights up. Snacks by squad if food is approved. Open the Wanted Poster table. Collect warrants into the cauldron. (The Detective handles the Chief's statement form.)
6. **2:40** Warrants read, Video 4 plays. Hand 3 blacklight flashlights to each squad. Stand by the lit hallway door during lights-out.
7. **2:48** Lights up. The Chief brings the Jar out. You run the trade: one tag, one squishy (candy layer first if there is one).
8. **2:55** Group photo with badges. Strike stations with the leads. Trash out. Tablecloths rolled and tossed.

Bin

- Spare badges (4 colors), 5 case files
- Spare TP, spare wipes, trash bags
- 20 evidence tags (highlighter-marked)
- 12 blacklight flashlights
- The EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy (goes to the Detective before 1:30)
- Camera or phone, photo opt-out list
- Squad list from the Chief

The one thing that can't slip

The 20 tags must be hidden before 2:40. If rotation 3 gets away from you, hide them during rotation 4.

You are the only adult without a station. Everyone will ask you for things.

DET

The Detective's cue card

Opening, the live beat after Video 1, the finale lines



Room parent · Trench coat, clipboard

1:30 · THE OPENING (LIGHTS OFF, 90 SECONDS MAX)

"Detectives, we have a situation. Sometime yesterday afternoon, the Party Candy Jar, the one you have been staring at for a week, disappeared from that shelf. We don't know when. Yet. The door was locked. The window was shut. Somebody on this staff knows something. We have four suspects. Three of them have recorded statements, and you'll hear from them as the investigation unfolds. The fourth, the Custodian, declined to comment. Make of that what you will. We have four pieces of evidence, and exactly one hour before the trail goes cold. Your squad has a case file. Fill it in. Clear the innocent and you'll know who did it. Chief _____ has assured me she is not a suspect. Let's begin."

1:49 · RIGHT AFTER VIDEO 1 (THE PRINCIPAL)

Let the room react for five seconds. Then: "Did... did the Principal just say squishies?" Reach into the coat. Pull out the EVIDENCE zip bag with one squishy. "Recovered from under that shelf this morning. I assumed it was unrelated." Turn to the Chief. "Chief. What exactly was in that jar?" *The Chief, flustered: "Candy. ...Mostly. Candy-adjacent."* Back to the room: "Detectives. That jar was never candy. Open your case files. Cross out 'candy.' Write 'squishies.' This changes nothing about the evidence and everything about the motive. Rotate."

2:02 AND 2:15 · AFTER VIDEOS 2 AND 3

One line each, then the bell. "The Reading Specialist does not understand squishies. Noted. Rotate." / "Check their feet. Hm. Rotate."

2:28 · THE FIFTH STATEMENT

The first squad to say "everyone's crossed off" gets it said for the room: "Then your list is too short. Four clues: size 9, in the building at 2:15, wore orange, loves squishies. Who else was in this building yesterday?" Let them guess. The Chief: "I am NOT a suspect." You: "Chief, you filled out a statement form like everyone else. For completeness. I have it right here." Pin it to the board next to the other four and read it aloud, including the crossed-out "Don't be ridiculous." "Detectives, check it against your clues. Then write your warrants."

2:40 · WARRANTS AND THE FINAL STATEMENT

Pull each warrant from the cauldron and read it aloud: "Squad 1 accuses... the Chief." The Chief protests: "This is outrageous. I'm the Chief." You: "There is one more statement. It was recorded under protest." Play Video 4. When it ends: "Detectives, you heard her. A very special light. In one minute the lights go out for three minutes. Flashlights to the squads. Every detective finds one tag. Then we open the Jar."